

CHESS MASTERY LIBRARY | FIRST EDITION

Attacking the King

Build attacks from access, force, and timing

THE PROMISE

Replace hope chess with a disciplined method for opening lines and sustaining threats.

VOLUME 08 OF 15

READ | RECALL | DECIDE | RETEST

What this volume should change

- Recognize when an attack is justified by development, access, and local force.
- Choose exchanges and sacrifices according to defenders and escape squares.
- Convert an attack into material or an endgame when mate is no longer available.

HOW TO STUDY

Read one section. Close the PDF and state its decision rule from memory. Solve the position lab before viewing the answer. Revisit the lab after two days and again after one week.

Inside this volume

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This volume is an original teaching synthesis of established chess ideas. Positions marked illustrative are designed to isolate a decision, not to replace full-game analysis. Board diagrams use Colin M. L. Burnett's Cburnett piece artwork from Lichess, licensed GPLv2+.

An attack needs a cause

A king attack is justified when the king is exposed or confined, your pieces can reach it quickly, and the center will not punish your commitment. Count attackers and defenders, but also compare the quality of their access.

Position cues

- Lead in development or more pieces near the king.
- Open or openable files, ranks, and diagonals.
- Weak color complex or missing pawn shield.
- Restricted escape squares and overloaded defenders.
- A stable enough center to permit wing operations.

PRACTICE RULE

Before attacking, name the entry line and the slowest attacking piece. If that piece cannot join, your local force may be insufficient.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

A space advantage near the king is not an attack until pieces have access and the opponent cannot strike the center.

Open lines with purpose

Pawn storms and sacrifices are line-opening tools. Decide which file or diagonal you need, what recapture will occur, and which piece will use the line. A pawn push that only touches the shield may help the king by giving it flight squares.

Position cues

- Pawn lever: force a capture or advance that changes the shield.
- File sacrifice: give material to open a rook or queen line.
- Diagonal clearance: remove your own pawn or an enemy blocker.
- Hook: an advanced enemy pawn that can be attacked to open a file.

PRACTICE RULE

Visualize the structure after each possible pawn capture. Choose the version that gives your pieces immediate access.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

Do not open lines when your opponent's heavy pieces will reach your king faster.

Map defenders and escape squares

A successful combination often removes one crucial defender or controls one last escape square. Draw a mental map of what protects the king, what can interpose, and where the king can run.

Position cues

- Defender count includes pieces that can arrive with tempo.
- Pinned defenders may be unable to move but can still control squares.
- Queen trades can be a defensive resource even when material is lost.
- The king's own pawns may both shelter and imprison it.

PRACTICE RULE

For each checking candidate, enumerate capture, block, and king move. If a defense exists, ask whether it can be removed first.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

Counting attackers and defenders mechanically misses geometry, pins, and move order.

Sacrifice only with compensation you can name

A sound sacrifice may produce mate, regain material, win the queen, create a durable bind, or force a favorable endgame. 'Initiative' is meaningful only when you can identify continuing threats and the opponent cannot consolidate.

Position cues

- Forced compensation: calculable mate or material recovery.
- Positional compensation: exposed king, trapped piece, enduring passed pawns, or domination.
- Time horizon: how many forcing moves remain before the defender consolidates?
- Decline: what happens if the opponent refuses the offered material?

PRACTICE RULE

Write the compensation before calculating: 'two pawns, open king, and perpetual-check floor.' Then test whether each claim survives.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

Do not use famous motifs as permission. The Greek gift, exchange sacrifice, and rook lift each require their positional conditions.

Bring every piece into the attack

Many attacks fail one tempo short because a rook, bishop, or queen remains disconnected. Multi-purpose improving moves can add force while preserving threats. A quiet rook lift or centralizing queen move may be stronger than another check.

Position cues

- Identify the attacker with no route and create one.
- Use tempo threats to improve another piece.
- Keep enough pieces to prevent queen trades and defensive exchanges.
- Switch wings when the defender overconcentrates.

PRACTICE RULE

After each forcing sequence, ask which reserve piece could join with tempo. Include quiet reinforcements among candidates.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

Do not move the queen repeatedly while minor pieces and rooks remain spectators.

Know when to cash out

An attack can succeed by winning material, creating a decisive endgame, or obtaining a perpetual when otherwise worse. When mate disappears, recalculate the value of simplifying. Preserving threats at any cost can throw away the result already earned.

Position cues

- Can you win material without allowing counterplay?
- Does a queen trade preserve a healthy extra pawn or exchange?
- Is perpetual check the safe floor of the position?
- Will continuing the attack expose your own king?

PRACTICE RULE

At every major defensive concession, pause and compare the best conversion with the best continuation of the attack.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

Do not treat mate as the only victory condition. The attacker must recognize when the position has changed phases.

Position Lab

Do not turn the page until you have written a candidate list or explanation. Score the process separately from whether your final answer is correct.

LAB 01

White to move. Before considering Bxh7+, list the conditions that must be checked rather than assuming the motif works.



Greek-gift conditions lab

BEFORE CHECKING

Name the cue, list at least two candidates or explanations, and test the strongest objection.

LAB 02

Your attack wins a pawn and forces a queen trade into an easily winning rook ending. You can instead keep queens on with an unclear attack. Which result should you prefer?

BEFORE CHECKING

Name the cue, list at least two candidates or explanations, and test the strongest objection.

Position Lab - Answers

LAB 01

Check whether the bishop sacrifice forces Kxh7 or can be declined, whether Ng5+ arrives with support, whether the queen reaches h7 or h5, whether Black can defend with ...Kg8, ...Re8, or a central break, and whether White has enough developed pieces. The diagram is a motif-recognition lab, not a claim that the sacrifice is automatically best.

LAB 02

Prefer the clear conversion unless a concrete defect makes the rook ending difficult. The purpose of the attack is to improve the result, not to preserve excitement.

Daily Study Card

Use this as a compact recall sheet. Say each item without looking, then open the volume only for the item you cannot explain.

- Name the access line and count useful attackers.
- Check the center before committing to a wing attack.
- Map captures, blocks, and king escapes.
- Name concrete compensation before sacrificing.
- Compare continuation with a safe conversion.

TRANSFER TEST

During your next five serious games, mark every position where this volume's cue appeared. Improvement means you noticed the cue and used a better process, even when the game result was noisy.

CONTINUE WITH

02_Defense_and_Counterplay.pdf

Personal notes